

A Colorful Sound

By Jason Blackschleger

Chapter I

Life often felt like a box office flop to me. Especially after discovering that I walked past the center idol of Lo☆TuS every time I went to college. My whole future seemed hopeless—like when you get the urge to walk out of a movie halfway through. Not because of jealousy, regret, or finding life unjust. Before I knew who she was, I'd already fallen in love with her.

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The first detail I ever noticed about her was a beauty mark under her right eye. The next was her exemplary taste in fashion. Unlike the typical streetwear that went for extravagant or eccentric, her outfits were sleek. Modest. Preppy. For anyone into Japanese fashion—yes, it was a niche hobby of mine—it could have best been described as Otona¹ Girly. She also liked to add a mask and sunglasses to her fit, which I assumed was to hide from fans.

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My parents always told me it was rude to stare. Fine in some parts of Europe, but not here in Japan. Admittedly, she didn't strike me as particularly interesting at first. Or so I thought. Every time the thought crossed my mind that she wasn't worth my attention, I found myself looking at her once more. An uninteresting woman doesn't catch your eye a dozen times. It must have been some kind of inner denial for me to assume I didn't care about her. Crazy to think how

¹ Literally just means adult

often we lie to ourselves because we refuse to accept something slightly embarrassing.

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Despite being the same age and being college students in Tokyo, we walked in opposite ways. Our lives were antiparallel—not meant to meet, with different destinations. The only place we ever crossed paths was at Nakano Station.

Nakano was usually a busy station, so once you caught a glimpse of someone, they'd already be way ahead of you. Not her, though. Like me, she took her time. Railway schedules were too fast to really care about being on time. Why run like all the others if the next train in the same direction was going to arrive seven minutes later? That was my stance on public transportation here. She must have come up with something similar, because she was the only one who never rushed out of the station. Instead, she stuck around for a while and spent her time window-shopping, needlessly taking the escalator up and back down again, or contemplating which drink to get at that lonely vending machine.

Right, the vending machine. The one thing we had in common. There were dozens of vending machines all around Nakano Station, but only a single one while transferring lines. It had your typical selection, from cola to milk tea, coffee to sports drinks. Usually, I stood there for a couple of minutes before either going with a Pocari like always or leaving without buying anything due to my own indecisiveness.

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I had always struggled with making decisions. One of the few important ones was to study literature at Sendai University—a rather mediocre choice. Now that I was about to graduate at the end of the semester, pressures started to build up. First came the pressure of more decisions. I chose to study to buy more time before entering adult life, but that time was about to run out. Then there was the academic pressure that loomed like a ticking time bomb. Graduating meant I had to finish that dreadful thesis of mine. Opting for a topic was another decision I first struggled to make and soon ended up regretting. Was time just always pressuring me? Did pressure speed up the time? It certainly impaired my judgment. By now, it was about eighty percent done. The remaining twenty percent was where my troubles lay.

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Of course, her school was more prestigious than mine. She exited the station to the south, which could only have meant that she attended Kamakurazono University—a private school with a tuition about twice as high as mine. Hell, I needed financial aid for Sendai. Kamakurazono was highly regarded for its entertainment faculty, having fostered many stars, producers, and other creative talent. Students are practically handed fame with the acceptance letter. In a way, I envied her because instead of being burdened by choices, she *was* chosen.

Her life and mine were not the same. We lived in different wards, moving in opposite directions, paying attention to separate moments—and she never looked my way.

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Living as far out as Hachioji while commuting to Central Tokyo came with the advantage of always having a spot to sit down for at least thirty minutes. That gave me plenty of time to write in my notebook. Over the years, I've built a habit of keeping a small notebook in my breast pocket and writing down anything that came to mind once I got inspired by something or someone else. My best ideas usually came to me when I didn't need them. Similarly, that was also how I fell in love: at a time when I didn't need it to complicate my life. Infatuation generally stalled my thoughts.

Still, I had ways to fill my notebook. In high school, idols proved to be just enough to get the pen moving. No, I wasn't ever into them. Never would I have considered myself a wota². They mostly served as writing inspiration and occasionally resulted in a handful of fan fiction. No details on that. Now that I was in my twenties, I was less inspired by idols.

Then came the one that stuck out like no one else.

I didn't figure out who she was all by myself. One day, my friend Hirosuke, whom I called Hiro, pointed out that there was a college for entertainment in Nakano. The group was getting pretty big around the time, so it was easy to look them up online. Sure enough, they were affiliated with Kamakurazono. Lo☆TuS consisted of nine members, each of whom could have been Japan's next obsession. I matched the mole under her eye in one photograph. That *was* her.

Name: Ayane.

Age: twenty years old.

Natural hair color: black.

² an obsessive fan

Hair color at the station: an earthy brown.

I kept my distance, standing in line behind her. Ayane held her chin and tapped her foot as she stood in front of the vending machine. She went on about it pretty vigorously, causing a neatly folded scrap of paper to slip out from under her cap. It hit the ground, but she didn't notice anything. I reached out my hand in an attempt to tap her on the shoulder and tell her about it. That could have been the first time our paths crossed. But fate wouldn't allow it. A middle schooler happened to walk, bent over, and picked the note up for Ayane. The idol shook her head back into reality and looked at the girl who held that note towards her. I was really just watching that all unfold, not being part of it in any way. That middle schooler's eyes lit up for a second. It was like she had her breath taken away from her once she realized who she was talking to. Ayane laughed and stayed calm. It was undoubtedly common for her to run into fans.

"Can we take a picture together? I want to show my classmates," the girl whispered with a shy undertone.

The girl pulled up her phone and inched closer to Ayane, who slipped her finger under her mask and revealed an enchanting smile. It was the kind of smile that came naturally and had the power to make someone fall in love. I tried not to stare.

The shutter went off three times. Aya pulled her mask back up and adjusted her cap, this time making sure that her note wouldn't slip out again. The girl bowed and moved on, blushing like this was the best day of her life. She waved back a couple of times with an overjoyed expression. Ayane held her hand up and smiled with her eyes until the girl was out of sight. And she sighed.

I had jitters in my neck, fearing the chance of becoming a bystander in my own story. Not because I was jealous of Ayane's fame or anything. That seemed pretty disruptive to her daily life. No, I was more disappointed at the idea that I missed some divine chance. What fucked me up more was that during all this, including me witnessing that scene, I felt transparent. Like I said, Ayane never looked my way. Which didn't mean she didn't know I was standing in line behind her. By now, she had turned around and was back to looking at the vending machine. Ayane did that jerking motion with her shoulders and straightened her neck, like when you realize you forgot you were supposed to do something.

She turned around again, this time towards me. "I'm sorry, am I holding up the line? Feel free to use the machine before me."

The way she switched up so fast to talk to me took me by surprise. "Oh, don't worry. I'm not in a hurry. I haven't decided on what to get yet."

Ayane laughed. "That makes two of us."

She looked at the machine for a couple more seconds until her phone started vibrating. *Bzzzt*. Some alarm, which she turned off as she let out a disgruntled 'egh.' Without saying anything else, she walked off towards the north exit while unlocking her phone and typing in a hurry. So all of that standing around amounted to nothing. I looked back until she was out of sight, then went ahead and selected a bottle of Pocari.

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I didn't see her once for the rest of the week. It was interesting that we had technically crossed paths now. But I knew it meant

nothing. Did I have a crush? Maybe. Should I have asked her out at an earlier point? Definitely not. Surely not during that one-sentence encounter we had. But we crossed paths.

‘This doesn’t mean anything. Forget about her.’—that’s what my brain was telling me.

But I have always been stubborn.

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There was another advantage to living out in Hachioji besides having a guaranteed seat on public transportation. It took fifteen minutes to get to a natural hot spring at the foot of Mount Takao. Going there had become somewhat of a ritual to go there with my friend Hirosuke, whom I called Hiro. Whenever we decided that we needed a break from things, that was the place to go. Today was such a day. Most often, Hiro was calm. He was the type of guy who had an answer for anything. Or almost anything. The only times he got somewhat frustrated were related to minor inconveniences.

There were dark rings under Hiro’s eyes today. We were on our way to the hot spring and had to wait for our connecting train at Takao Station. All Hiro wanted was a caffeinated beverage before relaxing in a scorching mineral pool. But the damned machine swallowed his money.

“I don’t know, Sota. This damned thing won’t do it,” he said while smacking the hull of the machine, hoping it would return his ten yen.

“You can’t buy anything with ten yen,” I said. “Let’s go.”

“It’s about the principle.”

“There’s a principle in knowing when to give up, too.”

Hiro took his fingers out of the compartment for the change and cracked open his third coffee. There were still about three minutes until our train came. Although I had no reason to get anything to drink, these machines tempted me every time. All except this one. If it weren't for this particular machine lacking tap-to-pay, I'd be sipping on something right now. We were still living in a cash-oriented society, but I always questioned the point of taking my wallet with me. There were viable digital alternatives. You'd have thought that in this day and age, most vendors would have switched to digital. Not that one. It needed coins. Which didn't matter that day, considering I recently made a new batch of tea that was waiting for me in my fridge at home. The only reason that machine tempted me so often was its convenient location. Its placement was on the way from the Tozai Line, along the way leading to the tracks that were labeled in that familiar orange 'JC'. Hiro went on ahead, forcing me to catch up. He had that habit where he sped up whenever he saw where he wanted to go. For example, any restaurant. As soon as he saw it, he walked noticeably faster. That meant I had to pick up the pace, too. On some occasions, my legs sped up before he even did anything. I knew his habits all too well.

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I've known Hiro since our first day in kindergarten. He drew on my leg with a red marker, and our caretaker convinced herself I somehow cut my leg. When my parents were notified and realized the caretaker's mistake, they gave her a big earful. I didn't care. It was funny. Hiro seemed funny. We've been best friends ever since.

My father was a white-collar worker. Liquidity specialist associate, to be precise. No, I never asked him what that meant, and I couldn't explain it to anyone. My mother was an editorial assistant at the

Chunichi Shimbun. Guess that explained why I was into literature so early. Our family lived right across the street from Hiro's parents.

Later in high school, Hiro and I applied for the same universities and ended up both getting admitted to Sendai University. However, this time we didn't live near each other. Hiro found a nice apartment in Mitaka, but the rents in that area were a bit over what I was comfortable with. So I ended up moving to Hachioji, which was about half an hour further out of Tokyo than Mitaka, and half as exciting to live in. I lived in that typical cheap neighborhood, the one where only kei cars fit on the roads. On the upside, we were both on the Chuo Line and had to transfer at Nakano Station to get to campus.

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"So, the prof approved your idea?" I asked.

Hiro was only half listening with that machine around. "Oh, yeah. My approach for how exactly I want to do an empirical study needs to be reworked, though. I bit off more than I could chew."

"So you're not doing an actual study after all?"

"Best case would be an online questionnaire."

"I liked your idea more. Would feel more scientific."

"I thought that's the point of going to university. In my opinion, they should let us literature majors write. Not like what they did with you."

"It's for the best," I said. "Can't submit a fanfic as a thesis."

Hiro sighed. "You can write anything once you're done, though. Also, leave the fan fiction for MelonSota."

"Don't—say that name. God, cringe."

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メロン創太 or MelonSota was my moniker on Pixiv. When I chose an alter ego to publish my work under, a wordplay on my name sounding like soda seemed quirky. I really liked melon soda at the time. But time went on. As I aged, the cornier I found that name. I always considered changing it, but I wanted to wait and use a better one once I went pro. There was also the threat of my family discovering I wrote that kind of stuff, so I never dared to use my real name. Hiro knew I hated it and would still call me Soda from time to time.

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I could feel my skeleton relax as I sank into the piping hot outdoor bath and let out a big sigh. The water went up to my neck. Hiro placed his towel on his head and sat down cross-legged next to me, his back straight as a candle.

Hiro yawned. “Gosh, I finished another third of my manuscript last night.”

“When’s the deadline again?” I asked.

“End of the month.”

“Did you sleep at all last night?”

“No way. Past midnight is when I get my best ideas. Something about sleep deprivation just spices up my creativity.”

“Or that’s you starting to hallucinate,” I joked.

Hiro shrugged. “Perhaps. But it’s worked out so far. You should give it a try sometime. Or just enter a contest for once.”

“I would if you didn’t enter all of them. No point going for second place.”

“Who says I’m better than you?”

“Well, you win literature scholarships all the time.”

Hiro shrugged. “I do it for the money. Mitaka can be pricey.”

“You don’t have to live in Mitaka.”

“You can afford more than Hachioji. Doesn’t it cost the same because you have extra train expenses?”

“I’ve never done the math, to be honest.”

“So you know, I lost more contests than you’ve ever signed up for. Sure, guess I got a record to show for myself. But I’ve never actually beaten you because we never competed against each other.”

“So when will you go for the Akutagawa?” I asked.

Hiro pondered. “My mom would kill me for not having a Fields Medal instead.” He got up and kind of shook his ass around to dry off. “Wanna hit up the hotter one over there?”

There was indeed an opaque-looking section that was marked five degrees hotter than the water we were currently in. Hiro waddled over buck-naked and sat down opposite an older guest who had his eyes closed. As I got up to follow my friend, my body let me know that my movements were too sudden. Black. I lost my vision for a second. Now I really craved some milk.

“I’ll try,” I said once I rejoined Hiro. “My notebook should have at least one idea I could turn into a story for a contest.”

Hiro stared at the old man, who seemed as rigid as a statue. “Oh, I’m sure it does. The hard part comes when you have to decide which idea to commit to.”

As far back as I could remember, I've loved stories. I've started dozens of novellas that, admittedly, needed to be finished at some point. It always seemed to me as if there were a billion ideas in my head at all times. To my parents' detriment, those didn't come with billions of yen. Nevertheless, they've always supported me, and both have allowed me to pick this major. My dad was a bit disgruntled when I told him I wanted to be a writer, but he wasn't the kind of parent who forbade me from chasing my dreams. He believed that if I couldn't make it, that would be an appropriate lesson. If I did make it, then he'd be able to live in good conscience, having known he always let me be who I was.

Ironically, the biggest threat to my writing was Sendai University. Most papers were supposed to be academic, based on research, and not at all what their website promised me in high school. We weren't actually meant to be creative. That really went against my usual writing flow. Like any author, I wrote because I've always done it. That was also why I kept a notebook. I knew when an idea was worth putting on paper. But my best ones usually came to me when I didn't need them.

The only real issue came with getting older. Time went on. The more ideas came, the less I knew what to do with them. It essentially resulted in some weird form of writer's block that not only halted my creative endeavors but also my academic ones. My thesis was stuck at eighty percent. The way things were in my head, there was no way of moving on with it, either.